

KING MIDAS

In return for helping one of the gods, King Midas was granted a wish. Greedily, he asked that everything he touched be turned to gold. When his food, drink, and even his daughter turned to gold, Midas begged for the gift to be taken away.



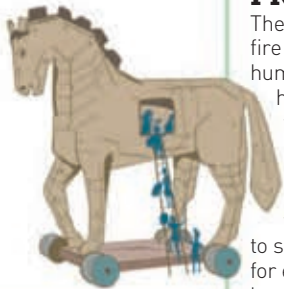
BELLEROPHON AND PEGASUS

The young hero Bellerophon rode a magical winged horse called Pegasus. Too bold and proud, he tried to fly up to the home of the gods. This so angered Zeus, he made Pegasus rear up and throw Bellerophon, who was injured. Lame and blind, he became a beggar.



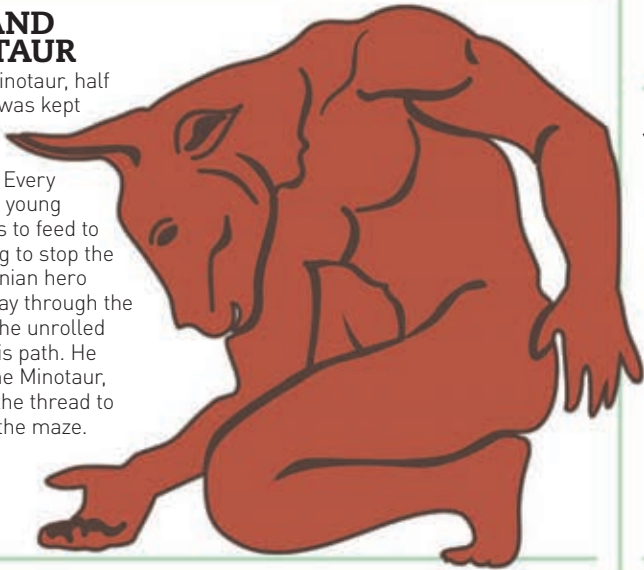
THE TROJAN HORSE

The Greeks defeated their Trojan enemies by trickery. Outside the city of Troy they left a huge wooden horse, which the Trojans seized. At night, men hidden inside the horse crept out to open the city gates for the Greek army.



THESEUS AND THE MINOTAUR

The flesh-eating Minotaur, half man and half bull, was kept by King Minos of Crete in a winding labyrinth, or maze. Every year, Minos took 14 young people from Athens to feed to his monster. Vowing to stop the slaughter, the Athenian hero Theseus found a way through the maze. As he went, he unrolled a thread to mark his path. He fought and killed the Minotaur, and then followed the thread to find his way out of the maze.



DEMETER AND PERSEPHONE

Demeter, goddess of grain, had her daughter Persephone stolen by Hades, king of the Underworld. While she grieved, the crops all died. Hades agreed to send Persephone back every spring and summer, so that the corn and flowers could flourish. In winter, when she went back to Hades, nothing grew.



DEMETER



PERSEPHONE

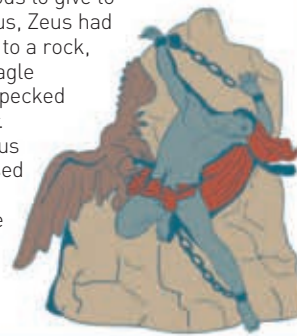
MEDUSA

The Gorgon Medusa, a monster with snakes for hair, could turn people to stone with one look. Perseus, a son of Zeus, killed her. He avoided her gaze by aiming at her reflection in a shiny shield lent to him by the goddess Athena.



PROMETHEUS

The Titan Prometheus stole fire from the gods to give to humans. Furious, Zeus had him chained to a rock, where an eagle constantly pecked at his liver. Prometheus was supposed to stay chained for ever, but the hero Heracles rescued him.



JASON AND THE GOLDEN FLEECE

Jason was heir to a kingdom that had been taken from him in childhood. To earn his throne he had to steal the fleece of a magical golden ram. Jason found the fleece, but it was guarded by a terrible serpent. He asked the hero Orpheus to charm the serpent to sleep with music. Jason seized the fleece and was allowed to claim his throne.



PANDORA'S JAR

Zeus made a beautiful woman out of clay. He brought her to life and called her Pandora. When she married, he gave her the gift of a sealed jar, telling her not to open it. Pandora's curiosity got the better of her and she opened the lid. All the evil things in the world, such as hatred, disease, and war, flew out. Then one last tiny thing came out of the jar – hope for the future.



THE 12 LABOURS OF HERACLES

When the hero Heracles went mad and killed his wife, he was punished by being given 12 seemingly impossible tasks.

1 THE NEMEAN LION

The lion had such tough skin that no spear could pierce it. Heracles managed to strangle the beast.

2 SLAYING THE HYDRA

The Hydra was a many-headed monster. Every time Heracles cut off one of its heads, two new ones appeared. By sealing each wound he stopped more heads from growing.

3 THE KERYNEIAN HIND

After a long and gruelling chase, Heracles caught a golden-horned deer belonging to the goddess Artemis.



4 THE ERYMANTHIAN BOAR

Heracles defeated this ferocious boar by trapping it in a snowdrift.

5 THE AUGEAN STABLES

The filthy stables of King Augeas had never been cleaned. Heracles changed the courses of two rivers to wash all the dirt away.

6 THE STYMPHALIAN BIRDS

To get rid of some monstrous birds, Heracles frightened them into the air by playing castanets, and then shot them.

7 THE BULL OF KING MINOS

Heracles captured a huge and dangerous bull belonging to the king of Crete.



8 THE MAN-EATING MARES

Heracles tamed a herd of dangerous meat-eating horses by feeding their owner to them.

9 THE BELT OF HIPPOLYTA

Hippolyta was queen of the Amazon women and terrifying in battle. Heracles dared to steal her valuable belt.

10 THE CATTLE OF GERYON

Sent to the edge of the world, Heracles stole the cattle belonging to a giant herdsman.

11 GOLDEN APPLES OF HESPERIDES

In yet another theft, Heracles took the precious apples belonging to the daughters of Atlas, the giant who carried the world on his shoulders.

12 VISITING THE UNDERWORLD

In his final task, Heracles went to the Underworld and captured the three-headed dog, Cerberus, that guarded the gates. The hero was finally forgiven for his crime.

THE ODYSSEY

Among the most often-told myths are the adventures of the hero Odysseus. After fighting in the Greek war against the Trojans, Odysseus spent many years on a dangerous sea voyage trying to get back home. The journey of Odysseus and his sailors is described in the story known as *The Odyssey*.

Odysseus's ships visit the lotus-eaters. These lazy people offer the sailors fruit that will make them forget the past.



Poseidon, the sea god, sends terrible storms to send the ships off course.

Circe, an enchantress, turns Odysseus's men into pigs and then back to men again.



Odysseus sails past the Sirens, who try to lure ships into dangerous waters with their song.

The sailors kill cattle on an island belonging to Helios the Sun god. Zeus strikes their ship with a thunderbolt, killing everyone but Odysseus.

Now the only survivor, Odysseus washes up on the island of the goddess Calypso, where he stays for seven years.

THE VOYAGE HOME



One-eyed giants called the Cyclopes keep the men captive and eat some of them. Odysseus blinds one of the giants and the crew escapes.

The giant Laestrygonians eat one of the sailors, and throw rocks at the ships, sinking all but one.



Odysseus visits the Underworld to find out his future. He has a vision of his homeland being invaded by enemies.

The ship sails the narrow channel between Scylla, a monster, and Charybdis, a whirlpool.



Odysseus finally returns home. He finds many men hoping to marry his wife, Penelope, and take his lands. Odysseus kills all the suitors and keeps his wife.